

Q&A

Your Questions, Our Answers

Away, Prying Eyes!

Q How can I encrypt a folder or file in Windows XP SP2? Can you suggest a free-ware for this purpose? WinZip takes a lot of time to encrypt folders.

Aakash

A You can use Windows' inbuilt encryption for encrypting / decrypting your files. The "cipher" command is used for this purpose. The syntax for encrypting files is as follows, with X as the drive letter (use this command at a command prompt):

cipher "X:\Path /E /A"

Encrypting your drive's contents will safeguard your data from the prying eyes

This will prevent all users—other than the one who encrypted the file or folder—from accessing it. The command for decrypting files encrypted this way is:

cipher "X:\Path /D /A"

If you need more flexibility in methods and speeds of encryption, we suggest FineCrypt from www.finecrypt.net. It will allow you to choose from up to 10 different algorithms, and is freeware.

Seeing Red

Q I have a Pentium 4 3.0 GHz HP 7540 branded system, 82915C/GV/910GL Express chipset family, 80 GB HDD, 256 MB DDR RAM. My display shows red vertical lines all over. This happens even when I change the monitor.

Muzafar Ahmad Ahanger

A Do the red lines appear even during POST (Power On Self Test) before Windows starts? If not, then you need to update your video card drivers to the latest available in order to eliminate any driver issues. Refer to your video card manufacturer's Web site for information on downloading the latest drivers.

If the red lines appear even during POST, it's

time to check your computer's insides. Go through the following checklist to narrow down your problem.

❑ If your video card is not onboard, then remove the card and re-insert it in the slot.

❑ It's also possible that the power supplied to your card might be fluctuating, especially if it uses a connector from your PSU to provide power. If it does, remove it and plug it in again—or use another connector if your PSU has similar connectors. You can also try your display card on another PC to see if the PSU is the cause of the problem.

❑ To eliminate any overheating issues, place a portable fan right next to your open cabinet, directly facing the video card. If the problem disappears, then you know your PC needs more efficient cooling. For tips, take a look at *Going With The Flow, Digit*, January 2007.

❑ Try another video card altogether, even if you have an onboard card. If everything seems fine, then the problem lies with the onboard video. You can then either look to using another video card or changing your motherboard.

We Don't Like No Pirates!

Q I downloaded the setup of Windows Media Player 11, but upon running it, I encounter an error message saying setup was unable to validate that my copy of Windows is genuine. Is there a way to solve this problem?

Atin Bansal

A While there are ways to get WMP11 to work in your situation, we can't assist you in this case—it would be aiding piracy. The only suggestion we can provide is for you to get a legal copy of Windows XP.

When Memory Doesn't Serve

Q I have an Intel 915GAV motherboard with an Intel Pentium 4 2.8 GHz processor, 256 MB of DDR RAM, and an 80 GB SATA HDD running Windows XP Media Center Edition. My computer is on 24/7. My problem is that after a couple of hours, it becomes very sluggish, taking more than a minute to start Firefox! I've tried using some memory clearing programs to free up memory, but nothing seems to work.

It was the same when I had XP with SP2 installed, so I tried changing the OS to Win XP Media Center. I've downloaded and installed all the new drivers for this OS. I also have ZoneAlarm, Avast!, and Microsoft AntiSpyware running in the background all the time. Will increasing the RAM work? If so, what amount would be sufficient? I'm not an avid gamer, but the system seems too slow to work with.

Arun Shanker Prasad

A Firefox taking a long time to start could be due to a large amount of cache stored; clear the cache. Keep it at 50 MB or so.

Your system turning sluggish after a couple of hours could be due to a program malfunctioning over a period of time and using up too much memory and/or CPU time. Look for this in the Task Manager. Memory usage should be in the range of 50 to 100 MB, and CPU usage should be above 50 per cent for the errant program.